as an exercise in realpolitik. Since the international order cannot be built on unrestrained competition, the quest to establish and uphold standards has always been relevant. This is perhaps even more relevant today in a world that is so much in ferment. The Ramayana could be studied from that perspective, highlighting both the merits and challenges of building a rules-based order.

The ethical dimensions of the Ramayana are exceptionally strong as compared to not only the Mahabharata but even to the epics of other cultures. Its grassroots understanding is one of a clear-cut battle of good against evil. This is why it is celebrated through festivals and fables across much of Asia. But even within this template, there are complexities, dilemmas and compulsions that hold lessons for a student of strategy. How goodwill is leveraged, commitments are made, coalitions are built and choices exercised are all graphically illustrated by the narrative. In most cases, the decisions appear obvious, yet, the crucial events have a backstory without which our understanding is not complete.

In essence, the Ramayana is a saga of a divine force that assumes human incarnation, Rama, to cleanse the world of evil. In that process, he sets the norms for personal conduct and promotes good governance. For that reason, we may see his rule as the epitome of a rules-based order, known as ‘Ram Rajya’. The narrative, as it unfolds, is understandably much more complicated than only these propositions. It begins with building strengths and acquiring capabilities that give Lord Rama, the chief protagonist, his formidable reputation. While subject to various tests, he is able to handle them with a dexterity that prepares him for the final challenge. His relationship with his half-brother Lakshmana is particularly close, though he also commands the affection of his two other siblings, Bharata and Shatrughna. The tale is one of political intrigue, as Rama’s stepmother Kaikeyi invokes one of the two boons given by his father Dasaratha to insist on Rama’s exile at the very time when he is to be crowned. The abduction, during his forest exile, of his wife Sita by the demon-king Ravana is the key event on which subsequent developments are centred.

As Rama prepares a campaign to rescue her, a number of stratagems emerge, all of which have found their way into folklore. The 10-day battle in which Rama is ultimately successful is not without its moments of anxiety. The role of Hanuman as his devotee, emissary, resource person and